

CORSAIR

A TABLETOP ROLEPLAYING GAME

PREAMBLE: A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

Funnily enough, my first tabletop roleplaying game wasn't Dungeons & Dragons. It was some obscure hungarian game called M.A.G.U.S., which if anything, helped me get a feel what I don't want from a roleplaying game. My second, and the first one I learned to run as a GM was Shadowrun. You might be able to spot a few influences here and there. I thoroughly fell in love with the setting but the rules were a bit too crunchy for my taste. That's when I started to experiment with rulesets. I probably tried to hack Shadowrun to be more friendly at least three separate times if not more.

Along the lines I discovered other games, systems, and game designers, each bringing something new to the table, but my other big muse was Blades in the Dark. John Harper's brilliant work was exactly on the opposite end of the spectrum when it came to complexity. You could create a character in less than fifteen minutes if you wanted to, and both you and your group had a clear identity and goal you were working toward. I still hope one day I get to be a player and not a game master in a Forged in the Dark game. That said...

I still found myself tinkering with the rules, trying to make them more complex this time around. I realised what I really wanted was somewhere in the middle. Something that could elegantly handle all the curveballs that players could throw at it with relatively simple mechanics. And somewhere along the line I ended up thinking, "what if I tried my hand at making my own system from scratch?" This is the result of that thought.

But this is the furthest I can go on without admitting how I'm standing on the shoulders of giants. I've already mentioned Shadowrun, and Blades in the Dark, but Dungeons and Dragons, Daggerheart, the Star Wars TTRPGs by Fantasy Flight Games were all crucial inputs to the final mechanics.

As far as the setting goes, where to even begin? I loved Destiny, Horizon Zero Dawn, Mass Effect, Guardians of the Galaxy, The Expanse and many more. I knew there were many other sci-fi settings out there, but I was really hoping that this specific idea of blending space fantasy with hard sci-fi would be original enough to stand out.

That said, it would have amounted to nothing if I didn't have help. From Large Language models too, putting so much words to, well, not paper but disk, but also, those people that listened to my pitches, rants, and ramblings, and gave me feedback along the way. Who were kind enough to sit down and play this with me when it was even bigger of a mess than it is now. I know most of you never expected yourself to appear in any sort of credits, but I hope this brings you some joy, or at least a good chuckle.

Special thanks to: Fábián János, Bangó Dávid

And an even bigger thanks to my wife and love of my life, **Farkas Ágnes**. I borrowed your ear more times than I can count, and you played a bigger role in making this a reality than anyone else.

Author & Lead Designer: Péter Csiszár
Version: 0.0.1

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SYSTEM INTRODUCTION

THE ELEVATOR PITCH

Corsair is a tabletop roleplaying game of high-stakes frontier adventure, tactical problem-solving, and found-family camaraderie, set against the vast backdrop of a macro-engineered cosmos.

You and your crew portray a **Corsair Cell**: licensed, independent operatives flying a versatile starship with a cross-jurisdictional charter. When local planetary law ends at the clouds and the naval peacekeepers of the Flotilla are light-hours away, your sponsors call on you. Whether you are investigating corporate sabotage in a spinning orbital arcology, braving derelict Precursor ruins for lost technology, negotiating tense standoffs across a fraying border, or scraping together enough fuel credits to keep your reaction thrusters burning, your crew stands as the thin line holding a young civilization together.

WHO ARE THE CORSAIRS?

THE SPHERE AT A GLANCE

The game takes place within the **Sphere**, a breathtaking engineered solar system featuring over a hundred terrestrial, habitable worlds and moons locked in tight binary orbits around colossal gas giants, all circling a quiet Orange Dwarf star.

Circa five hundred years ago, automated seed arks brought the survivors of four dying worlds into this seemingly abandoned system. Arriving as the **Newcomers**, humanity and three alien lineages—the cold-blooded, crested **Naga**, the dense-skinned **Craggen**, and the chlorophyllic **Sylvan**—made their first historic landfall on a fertile moon appropriately named **Landfall**. Over five centuries of shared survival, exploration, and cultural blending across the moons, six natural hybrid lineages took root alongside them: **Drakelings**, **Elves**, **Gnomes**, **Dwarves**, **Kobolds**, and **Trolls**.

Today, civilization spans dozens of bustling worlds, gleaming orbital transfer stations, and remote mining habitats. Yet the laws of nature remain stubbornly grounded. There is no faster-than-light warp drive; ships burn continuous fusion engines along calculated orbital curves. There is no artificial gravity plating; you stay grounded either through the axial acceleration of your ship's thrusters, the gentle centrifugal spin of a habitat drum, or the solid click of magnetic boots against steel decks. And in the vacuum of space, waste heat is as dangerous as an enemy round.

YOUR ROLE: THE CORSAIR CELL

Civilization across the moons is divided by a historic treaty: planetary governments hold total jurisdiction within their atmospheric gravity wells, while the peacekeeping fleet known as the **Flotilla** polices the open void and interstellar shipping lanes. This separation creates a glaring legal seam. Smugglers, corporate raiders, rogue mercenaries, and political conspirators routinely commit crimes under planetary clouds and burn into orbit, daring local authorities to chase them past their legal boundaries.

To bridge this seam, authorities grant independent charters to **Corsairs**—small, autonomous crews given cross-jurisdictional warrants to cross from planetary mud to the cold vacuum of orbit without getting bogged down in red tape.

As players, you form a **Corsair Cell**—a tight-knit crew of 3 to 5 specialists sharing an agile starship. Every cell is distinct:

- **Conflicting Sponsors:** Legitimate Corsairs are typically backed by multiple, competing sponsors—such as a Flotilla naval commander, a planetary governor, a commercial trading guild, or an independent labor union. By balancing competing patrons, your crew maintains its operational independence.
- **The Omni-Role Ethos:** You are practical survivors, not rigid archetypes. While every operative has specialized training or hardware rigs, no Corsair is locked into a single duty. Every member of the crew knows how to draw a sidearm in a corridor firefight, monitor a sensor array, pilot a shuttle, patch a ruptured environmental suit, and haggle for spare parts at an orbital bazaar.
- **Freedom of Approach:** Whether your crew acts as principled investigators, gritty salvage hounds, diplomatic fixers, or razor-sharp troubleshooters, how you tackle your contracts is entirely up to you.

WHAT IS A ROLEPLAYING GAME?

A roleplaying game (RPG) is a collaborative storytelling experience. You and your friends create characters to portray, and together you navigate a living world full of adventure, intrigue, and danger.

One player takes on the role of the **Game Master (GM)**. The GM is the primary storyteller, the referee of the rules, and the voice of the non-player characters (NPCs) that inhabit the void. The other players portray the **Player Characters (PCs)**, the specialist operatives who make up the Corsair crew and drive the story forward.

The game unfolds through a natural conversation:

1. **The GM describes the situation:** The environment, the sensory details of the scene, and any imminent hazards or NPCs present.
2. **The players declare their intent:** You state what your characters do, say, or attempt—whether moving into cover, overriding an airlock seal, or negotiating terms with a tense frontier marshal.
3. **The mechanics determine uncertain outcomes:** When an action is routine, it simply succeeds. But when an outcome is uncertain, dangerous, or contested, the dice hit the table using the rules outlined in this book.
4. **The GM describes the consequences:** The fiction moves forward, the scene shifts, and the conversation continues.

There are no winners or losers in a roleplaying game. The goal is to collaborate, face tactical challenges, and tell a memorable, cinematic story together.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED TO PLAY

To play Corsair, you will need a few essentials:

TABLETOP ESSENTIALS	
Dice	The game uses three standard polyhedral die types: eight-sided (**d8**), ten-sided (**d10**), and twelve-sided (**d12**) dice. A handful of each die type (especially d10s, which form the primary resolution dice pool) is ideal for the table.
Sheets	Printable sheets for recording your operative's attributes, skills, equipment, and your starship's modules (Character Sheet & Crew Sheet).
Pencils	Pencils and scratch paper for tracking notes, tactical sketches, and fluctuating game states (Action Points, Light Wounds, Aggravated Wounds, and ammunition).
Tokens	Simple counters (coins, poker chips, or glass beads) are useful for tracking Action Points and tactical positions during moment-to-moment encounters.
Group	Corsair is designed for **3 to 5 players**, including the Game Master.

> **THE PRINCIPLE OF NARRATION**
>
> Dice never roll in a vacuum. A roll represents physical friction: boots catching against grated decking, capacitors whining under peak load, or thruster gimbal bearings fighting reaction torque. Describe what your character physically does before picking up the dice.

READER'S GUIDE: HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This rulebook is organized into five functional sections designed to take you from foundational mechanics to active campaign play, interleaved with narrative fiction capturing the lived reality of the void:

PART I: CORE RULES & ENGINE

The fundamental mechanics that power every test, decision, and scene in the game.

- **Core Mechanics:** The foundational rules of Attributes, Attribute Pairs, Simple Tests (binary success), Success Tests (degree of achievement), Complex Tests (action + quality), Upgrades & Downgrades, Contests, Gambits, and Teamwork.
- **Scenes, Pacing & Action Points:** Zooming between Day-to-Day shifts and high-stakes Moment-to-Moment rounds, the 3 Action Point economy, turn swaps, teamwork actions, and delayed actions.
- **Effects:** Activating dynamic tactical opportunities by sacrificing Hits on Action Rolls (Chain, Upgrade/Downgrade, Blocker) and Success Rolls (Crit, Push).
- **Interlude:** *A Point of Order on the Twenty-Seventh Hour*

PART II: CHARACTER CREATION & CLASSES

Everything you need to conceive, build, and advance your Corsair operative.

- **Player Characters:** Core Attributes, Derived Attributes, Skills, and Condition (wounds and stress).
- **Character Creation:** Step-by-step procedures for assigning attributes, training skills, and choosing starting equipment.
- **Traits & Lineages:** Origin traits, cultural adaptations, and operational quirks that distinguish your operative's physiology and background.
- **Classes & MANTLE Rigs:** The five operational chassis: the energy-channeling **Conduit**, the biochemical **Hazard**, the drone-linking **Pilot**, the frontline bulwark **Vanguard**, and the nanite-weaving **Weaver**.
- **Advancement:** How operatives earn experience, refine skills, upgrade attributes, and achieve career milestones during downtime.
- **Interlude:** *Post War Head- and Heartaches*

PART III: ADVANCED OPERATIONS

The tactical systems, armaments, voidcraft, and operational downtime that keep Corsairs alive and solvent.

- **Tactical Combat:** Movement, grid and abstract occupancy, close-quarters combat (CQC), dynamic cover, and damage resolution.
- **Personal Armory & Hardware:** Catalogs of Firearms, Melee Weapons, Armor, Field Gear, and rare Precursor Exotic Hardware.
- **Starships & Space Combat:** Comprehensive rules for Starship Operations, Brachistochrone burns, Ship Weapons, Internal Modules, and The Hangar Bay.
- **Downtime & Operations:** The 24-hour downtime cycle, shifts, long rests, medical recovery, starship maintenance, commercial bazaars, and the master d100 freelance odd jobs table.
- **Interlude:** *The Mathematics of the Great Tithe*

PART IV: WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

The celestial gazetteer, faction dossiers, history, and fiction of the setting.

- **Planetary Gazetteer:** Macro-engineering of the Sphere, the Newcomer heartland in the Fume Cluster, the cradle of Landfall, and the X'ara Cluster.
- **Factions & Powers:** Dossiers on the Sovereign Colonies, Megacorporations, the Flotilla, and the Underworld.
- **The Corsairs & Timeline:** The legal mandate of Corsairs, the 500-year history since arrival, and master anthology Stories of the Sphere.
- **Interlude:** *Space Tourism*

PART V: RUNNING THE GAME

Procedures, campaign structures, threat rosters, and mission generators for running the game.

- **Running the Game:** Core guidelines for Time Management, Social Interactions, Stealth & Infiltration, Investigation, Chases & Pursuits, and Tracks.
- **Threats of the Sphere:** Tactical profiles and statblocks for corporate security, pirates, drone swarms, void horrors, and NPC Guidelines.
- **Missions & Contracts:** Procedural Mission Generator and Open Play Contracts.

> **FLIGHT CLEARANCE APPROVED**
> Proceed to the foundational resolution mechanics: **Chapter 01: Core Mechanics →**